

**Concession and Succession:
Where Escalation Buys Removal at the Price of an
Accountable Successor**

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Abstract

Two findings about campaigns against entrenched rulers are secure separately and have never been put in the same model. Nonviolent campaigns unseat incumbents more often than armed ones, and campaigns that escalate lose the participation that produces removal. Yet armed revolutions that do succeed resist counterrevolution, while sustained unarmed mobilization is what produces successors that answer to anyone. Escalation is therefore evaluated against one outcome at a time, and the outcomes are different. This paper couples them in a stipulated model and computes what the coupling implies. Three results follow. Making a campaign visible makes a ruler more likely to act rather than to concede: attention moves 610 waiting cases of the incumbent's decision problem to repression against 400 to concession, and though it enlarges the concession region from 0.158 to 0.286, escalation then cuts it to 0.102. Under repression a campaign's composition shifts toward its armed wing with nobody converting and nobody recruiting, reaching parity after 6.24 periods of maximal repression, by which point 0.025 of the original campaign is left standing. Coupling the two, escalation improves the odds of removal only where an intact civilian campaign could strip at most 0.0475 of the apparatus's cooperation; read where escalation looks best, it raises the probability of removal from 0.107 to 0.184 and retains 0.109 of the accountable succession that not escalating would have secured. Across 600 random parameter draws escalation helped removal in 62, and lowered accountable succession in all 62.

Two findings that were never put in the same model

An original dataset of major resistance campaigns between 1900 and 2006 established that nonviolent campaigns outperformed armed ones at achieving maximalist objectives, and proposed a mechanism: nonviolent campaigns attract broader participation and prompt loyalty shifts among the opponent's security forces, while armed campaigns mobilize comparatively few people and hand the opponent a justification for violent counterattack (Stephan and Chenoweth 2008). A companion result found that contemporaneous armed struggle does not improve an unarmed campaign's outcomes, and is negatively associated with popular participation and thereby with success (Chenoweth and Schock 2015). The proximate mechanism has been studied on its own: security-force defection heavily influences the outcome of nonviolent uprisings, and troops who receive benefits from the regime, or who believe the regime can survive the uprising, do not defect (Nepstad 2013). An agent-based treatment arrives at the same place by a different route, finding that targeting the regime's pillars of support generates more defections than rapid mass recruitment, even for small campaigns (Chenoweth et al. 2022).

Set against this is a second body of work about what comes after. Of the 280 autocratic regimes in existence between 1946 and 2010, transitions from one autocracy to another make up about half of all regime changes (Geddes et al. 2014), and a large literature describes the hybrid regimes that have resulted (Levitsky and Way 2010). Removal is a precondition for two further outcomes, and those two can fail independently of it and of each other. On one of them the evidence favours mobilization: across 112 young democracies in 80 countries, new democracies growing out of mass mobilization survive longer, and sustained *unarmed* uprisings produce the longest-lasting ones,

because such campaigns are forced to build an organizational structure that supplies a leadership cadre, links government to society, and constrains the post-transition government (Kadivar 2018). On the other the evidence runs the other way: violent revolutions are less likely to be reversed, because they produce regimes with strong and loyal armies, and violence lowers the likelihood of counterrevolutionary success without lowering the likelihood of counterrevolutionary emergence (Clarke 2022).

These two findings answer different questions: whether the successor survives, and whether it answers to the people who put it there. Each holds the other fixed. Nobody has asked what happens to all three quantities when a single decision moves. That decision is not hypothetical: movements are collections of factions rather than unitary actors, and escalation is likely when a movement contains violence-wielding factions and the campaign is failing to make progress through nonviolent channels (Ryckman 2019). Escalation is selected precisely where the nonviolent route looks blocked, which is where the model below finds it does the most damage.

What follows is a model. Its functional forms are stipulated and are stated in full; nothing is fitted to any campaign, no probability here estimates any real probability, and no country appears. Its interest is that each of its three mechanisms is familiar on its own and their interaction is not. Three grids are swept exhaustively and one robustness test uses a seeded random ensemble; twenty-four invariants are enforced and a failed invariant fails the run.

What the incumbent is choosing between

A ruler facing a campaign has three answers available in each period: concede, repress, or wait. The model compares them on the ruler's own perceived cost, which is not the cost to anyone else. The choice between conceding and repressing under the threat of revolution has a canonical formal treatment (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006); this model differs in giving the ruler a third option, in making the price of repression depend on the apparatus rather than on the ruler's resources, and in carrying the consequences of the choice forward into what succeeds them.

Conceding costs a base amount plus a term in the campaign's escalation, because a ruler who expects to be killed or tried after leaving office values staying more highly. This is the one place the model borrows a result rather than stipulating a shape: the less punitive the consequences of losing office, the more a leader will concede to strike a bargain (Debs and Goemans 2010). Repressing costs a base amount divided by the cooperation the coercive apparatus still extends, plus terms in outside attention and in the material leverage the campaign has withdrawn. The division is the important part. Force is cheap while the institutions that carry it out cooperate and expensive as they stop, which is the standing insight of the literature on authoritarian rule as a bargain with subordinates who can withdraw (Svolik 2012; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003). Waiting costs a base amount plus terms in leverage and attention: delay is what disruption makes expensive.

Two parameters describe the campaign. *Leverage* is the fraction of material cooperation it has withdrawn through strikes, boycotts and non-payment. *Attention* is how visible the confrontation is

to parties whose reaction the ruler must price. The decision is mapped over a grid of 4896 cells spanning institutional cooperation and leverage.

Raising attention from low to high does not simply push a ruler toward concession. It raises the cost of waiting and the cost of repression at the same time, and so converts cases out of delay in both directions. Of the cells where a low-attention ruler would wait, 610 move to repression and 400 move to concession, a ratio of 1.525. Visibility makes a ruler *act*; which way it makes them act is a separate question with a separate answer in each cell. This is the model's version of a caution the empirical literature has already issued from the other side: dissent and repression are endogenous, and where a government represses preventively, observed dissent does not predict responsive repression (Ritter and Conrad 2016).

On net attention still helps. The concession region grows from 0.158 of the swept region at low attention to 0.286 at high attention. But escalation then cuts it to 0.102, a loss of 0.183, larger than attention's gain. A campaign that becomes visible and then escalates ends with a smaller set of conditions under which the ruler finds conceding cheapest than it had before it did either.

The boundary has a closed form. Repression stops being the cheapest answer when institutional cooperation falls below $\beta_r/(\kappa - \alpha_a a - \alpha_\ell \ell)$, where κ is the cost of conceding, a attention and ℓ leverage. With attention high, cooperation must fall to 0.280 before conceding is cheapest against a campaign with no material leverage, and to 0.526 against one that has withdrawn all of it. Leverage nearly doubles the institutional cooperation a ruler can still command and yet find concession the cheapest answer. The simulated boundary matches the closed form at every level of leverage to within one grid step. Where the campaign has no leverage and nobody is watching, no cell concedes at all; the ruler simply waits, which is the cheapest thing a ruler with nothing pressing on them can do.

Composition changes without anyone changing their mind

The second mechanism requires no decision by anyone. Civilian organizations need assembly, publicity, open membership and public identification; clandestine armed organizations need less of each. Give the two wings of a campaign different retention rates under repression, with the civilian wing more sensitive, and the composition of what survives moves on its own.

The odds ratio between the wings after t periods is $\frac{w_t}{1-w_t} = \frac{w_0}{1-w_0} \left(\frac{s_A}{s_C} \right)^t$, where s_A and s_C are the two retention rates. This is verified against period-by-period iteration; the invariant requires agreement to within 10^{-9} and the observed disagreement is at the level of double-precision rounding.

A campaign that begins with 0.1 of its capacity in an armed wing, subjected to maximal repression, reaches parity between the two wings after 6.24 periods. At that point 0.025 of the original campaign is still standing. Run to a fixed six periods, maximal repression leaves the armed share at 0.479 and total capacity at 0.029; the same six periods with no repression leave the armed share at

0.119, barely above where it started. Nobody in this calculation converts, recruits, or changes their mind about anything.

The effect lives entirely in the differential. Set the two sensitivities equal, so that repression falls on both wings alike, and the armed share after six periods is 0.1, exactly where it began. What moves the composition is not violence but selectivity, which is a claim about what repression is good at rather than about how much of it there is. This is consistent with the finding that different instruments do different work for a ruler: political terror suppresses organized threats while restrictions on civil liberties deter collective action, and the two have different effects on how a dictator eventually leaves (Escribà-Folch 2013).

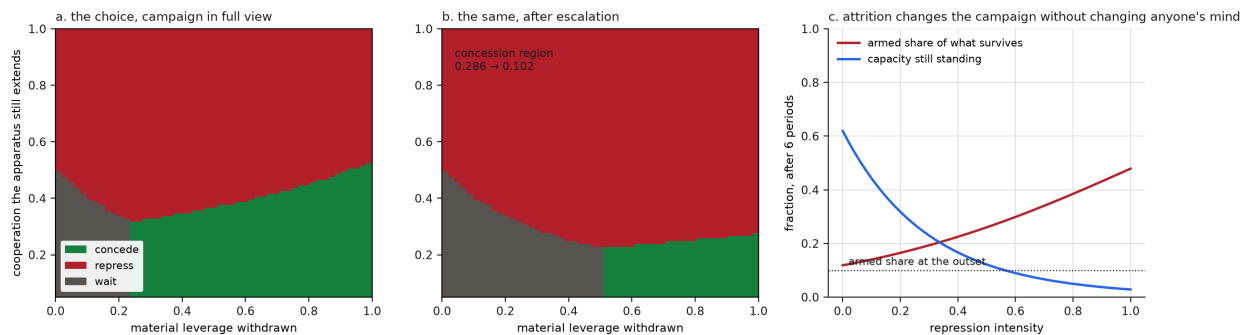


Figure 1: The incumbent's decision and the attrition of the campaign. (a) The cheapest answer for a ruler over institutional cooperation and withdrawn leverage, with the campaign in full view. (b) The same map after the campaign escalates: the concession region contracts from 0.286 to 0.102 of the region. (c) The armed share of surviving capacity and the total capacity still standing, after six periods, against repression intensity. The armed share rises with repression while what it is a share of collapses.

That last panel is the reason the two mechanisms have to be coupled. The armed share rises with repression and the thing it is a share of collapses at the same time. Any argument that reads only the first curve concludes that repression radicalizes a campaign; any argument that reads only the second concludes that repression destroys it. Both are happening, and what an escalating campaign is choosing is a point on both curves at once.

Three outcomes and three maxima

Now the coupling. Escalation in the model means two things together: the campaign deliberately shifts its own composition toward an armed wing, and that shift draws heavier repression. Escalation is allowed to help. An armed wing can remove an incumbent by force without waiting for the apparatus to defect, and the model gives it that channel explicitly: the probability of removal is driven by withdrawn cooperation *and* by the armed wing's capacity relative to what remains of the regime's coercive strength.

Three outcomes are then scored separately. Removal is the incumbent leaving. Durability is the successor surviving, and rises with the armed capacity the new regime inherits, which is the mech-

anism Clarke identifies. Accountability rises with the *civilian* capacity that survives and falls with the armed share of what is left, which is the mechanism Kadivar identifies. Nothing forces the three to peak together, and the point of the exercise is to find out whether they do.

The institutional condition is reduced to a single interpretable quantity: how much of the apparatus's cooperation an intact civilian campaign could strip. An apparatus that can be stripped of a lot is responsive to domestic noncooperation; one that can be stripped of little is insulated, whether by coup-proofing, foreign patronage, ethnic stacking or simple indifference. Sweeping this quantity against escalation locates the conditions under which escalation improves the odds of removal at all, rather than assuming them.

The answer is a narrow corner. Escalation raises the probability of removal only where an intact civilian campaign could strip at most 0.0475 of the apparatus's cooperation, which is 0.083 of the swept range. Everywhere else the civilian channel is the better route to removal and escalation is simply worse on every one of the three outcomes at once. This is the model reproducing the empirical baseline it was built to respect, and it should be read that way: the general finding that escalation is counterproductive is not overturned here, it is localized.

Inside that corner the three outcomes come apart. The fairest place to read them is the institutional condition under which escalating buys the largest gain in the probability of removal, since that is where the case for escalation is strongest. There, escalation raises the probability of removal from 0.107 to 0.184, a gain of 0.078. Removal peaks at escalation 0.61. Durability peaks at 0.61 as well: the successor that escalation produces is more likely to survive, exactly as Clarke's mechanism predicts. Accountability peaks at 0. Escalating to the level that maximizes removal retains 0.109 of the accountable succession that not escalating would have secured.

That is the coupling. Over 0.61 of the escalation range, the probability of removal is rising while the probability of a removal that produces an accountable successor is falling, and over that same range durability is rising while accountability falls. An argument that escalation "works" and an argument that it does not can both be correct in the same case, about different things, and the disagreement between them is not empirical but a disagreement about which outcome is being scored.

Whether the divergence survives other parameters

A model with a dozen stipulated constants can be made to say almost anything at one hand-chosen point, so the divergence is tested across an ensemble. Every constant is perturbed by an independent uniform factor between 0.6 and 1.4, the institutional condition is drawn at random, and the whole analysis is rerun. Across 600 such draws, escalation raised the probability of removal in 62 of them. In all 62 it lowered accountable succession. The best case across the entire ensemble retained 0.171 of the accountability that not escalating would have secured; the median retained 0.066. Where escalation helped, the median gain in the probability of removal was 0.050, which is real and in the model never free.

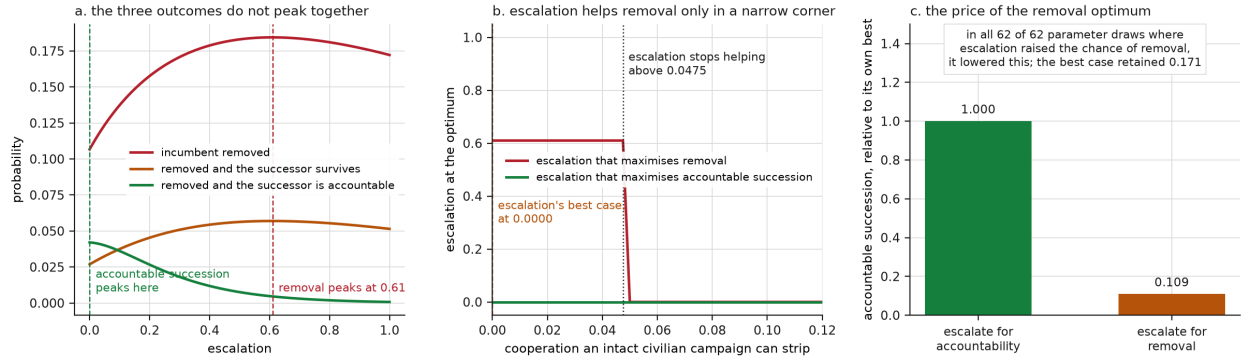


Figure 2: Removal, durability and accountability under escalation. (a) The three outcomes at the institutional condition where escalation buys the largest gain in the probability of removal; removal and durability peak at escalation 0.61, accountability at 0. (b) The escalation maximizing each outcome, against how much cooperation an intact civilian campaign could strip; escalation stops helping removal above 0.0475. (c) Accountable succession under the removal-maximizing choice, relative to what the accountability-maximizing choice would have secured.

The strongest case against this conclusion is experimental and comes from the radical-flank literature. Two experiments with 2,772 participants found that the presence of a radical flank increases support for a moderate faction in the same movement, that it is radical tactics rather than a radical agenda that produces the effect, and that the mechanism is contrast: the moderate faction appears less radical (Simpson et al. 2022), an effect first proposed decades earlier (Haines 1984). That finding is not in dispute here and the model does not contradict it, because it measures a different quantity. Third-party support for a faction is not the campaign's organizational capacity, and neither is the character of the regime that follows. The model's claim is about what is left standing after repression selects among a campaign's parts, and about what that residue can build. A flank effect that raises sympathy while the differential attrition of the same tactics is destroying the civilian organization would produce exactly the pattern computed here.

The other case against it is that a campaign in the narrow corner has no better option. If the apparatus genuinely cannot be stripped, the civilian route to removal is closed, and 0.109 of an accountable succession may be the best available. The model does not dispute this and cannot: it prices a trade-off, it does not tell anyone which side of it to take. What it does establish is that the trade-off is there, that it is not small, and that the condition under which escalation helps removal is the same condition under which it costs the most. Nothing in the model licenses the inference that because escalation raised the chance of removal, it improved the situation.

What is not being claimed

The functional forms are stipulated. The exponential retention, the multiplicative accountability term, the additive cost structure of the incumbent's decision and the hazard form of removal are choices, made to be transparent rather than because any of them was estimated. The ensemble tests

whether the conclusion survives perturbation of the constants; it does not test whether it survives different functional forms, and that is a real limit.

Two mechanisms known to matter are absent. Repression that backfires, mobilizing more people than it removes, is not in the model, and it is well documented: whether repression of unarmed protest backfires depends on pre-existing campaign infrastructure and parallel media, which raise both domestic mobilization and security defections after violent repression (Sutton et al. 2014; Hess and Martin 2006), and exposure to a regime's past repression can raise later participation (Lawrence 2016). Including backfire would raise the returns to remaining unarmed and would strengthen the paper's conclusion, which is why its absence is stated rather than repaired: the result reported here is the one obtained *without* the mechanism that would favour it. Also absent is concession from strength, in which a ruling party embraces democratization because it expects to keep winning (Slater and Wong 2013). The incumbent here concedes only when conceding is the cheapest of three costs, which is a narrower ruler than the literature describes.

The differential sensitivity of clandestine and open organizations to repression is the parameter the second section rests on, and no empirical estimate of it was found. The paper stipulates two values, reports the null in which they are equal and the composition does not move at all, and states that the magnitude of every result in the second section is a function of a quantity nobody has measured. The direction of the effect follows from the organizational argument; the size does not.

Three further things the model treats as given are not. It reads institutional cooperation as a quantity available to the ruler, and no ruler's is: where preferences are falsified, an apparatus can look cooperative until the moment it stops being so (Kuran 1991). It says nothing about what an armed wing becomes, which depends on how it recruits and on what resources are available to it (Weinstein 2006), or about whether a fragmented movement can hold a nonviolent line at all (Pearlman 2011). And it takes the campaign's existence as given, where the conditions that produce major nonviolent campaigns are themselves a subject of study (Butcher and Svensson 2014; Chenoweth 2020).

The model contains no country, no campaign and no ruler, and its probabilities are properties of stipulated functions rather than estimates of anything. No parameter here was estimated from campaign-level data such as NAVCO (Chenoweth and Shay 2022) or event-level data such as ACLED (Raleigh et al. 2010), and nothing in it is fitted to them; as it stands the model makes no prediction those data could refute. It is not advice. A campaign deciding whether to escalate faces a question about a particular apparatus, a particular set of factions and a particular set of consequences, none of which is in here. What is in here is a structure: that removal, durability and accountability are three outcomes rather than one; that a single decision can move them in different directions; and that the institutional conditions under which escalation improves the first are the conditions under which it costs the most of the third. Where the field's two findings appear to conflict, it is worth checking first whether they are scoring different outcomes, because in this model they always are.

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